



The Bandwidth OF GROWTH

Let information technology be an integral part of every aspect of human development—from healthcare to security

— By **SIVAKUMAR RAMAMURTHY**

Inclusive growth is not just a buzzword; it is a vital requirement for developing democratic nations like India. Information and Communication Technologies (ICT), made possible by ubiquitous broadband infrastructure and affordable access to computing, can play a pivotal role in the nation's continued accelerated growth needs. This growth is one that penetrates down to every citizen.

India's rise as a knowledge economy has had ICT as its cornerstone. The mobile telephony revolution has connected people from all walks of life to each other. However, it would be short-sighted for us to stop at those laurels. There is a lot of distance to cover—on the ICT readiness index, India ranks a

dismal 118, far behind other emerging economies, Brazil (60), Russia (50) and China (73). Even in terms of percentage of GDP, ICT contributes a meagre 4.68 per cent, when it should have been no less than 10 per cent.

The time for debates and discussions is over. It is time to execute. ICT has to move into the core of social, economic and governance systems and processes, and not remain a retrofit. It has to be seen as an element of basic infrastructure, the way transport, ports and power are viewed today. Broadband connectivity is a goal towards which we have to move aggressively. Internet connection is to the 21st century what electricity was to the 20th. The sooner we get connectivity to the hands

of every individual in the country the better.

The Government's *aam aadmi* thrust for development is visible. It is, however, essential to view ICT as an integral part of every aspect of human development—from healthcare to education, from security to environmental protection. Take, for example, education. The typical idea of ICT in education is to dump a few computers in the school and then wait for them to magically transform the lives of the students. That does not work. A holistic approach that includes teachers, curriculum enabled by technology and the Internet, methods of instruction and evaluation and a process to involve parents in the education, is crucial to developing the workforce for the informa-

Every year 30 lakh graduates and post-graduates join the workforce; only 25 per cent of technical graduates and 10-15 per cent of others are employable. A one per cent shift in budgetary allocation can make them more productive.

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is the number of mobile connections India will have by 2012. China and India will account for 31 per cent of world's mobile connections.